

Scadta, the first permanent airline in the Americas, was founded in Colombia by German expatriates in 1919 and began service in 1920.

Slow start in the US

So why were travelers in the United States so slow to take to the air? Although it had an excellent railroad network, the country was built on the right scale for air transportation, its continental expanse offering airplanes the chance to deliver major time-saving, as the US Air Mail quickly proved. But it was hard to persuade Americans to take flying seriously. Mesmerized by the antics of the barnstormers, the public failed to see the airplane as a straightforward way of getting from place to place. Most of the passenger services that did operate in the immediate postwar years were an amusing start to a vacation break – for example, trips from New York City to resorts on Long Island or in New Jersey, run by Aeromarine. Aviation in America seemed stuck with an image of frivolity and danger that deterred potential investors and customers alike.

Relatively free of the international rivalries and national-defense concerns that motivated

European governments, in the early 1920s the US federal government adopted a hands-off approach, neither supporting nor regulating commercial aviation. But a turning point came in 1925, with the decision to make the Post Office hand over the thriving US Air Mail network to private companies. Since no such companies yet existed, the federal authorities were in effect committed to creating the conditions in which they could flourish. Like elsewhere in the world, commercial aviation in the United States would be less the product of buccaneering free enterprise than of government handouts, public investment in infrastructure, and strict regulation to uphold standards and protect the new airlines from the cold winds of competition.

The first necessity was to persuade the public that flying was safe. Under the 1926 Air Commerce Act, all commercial aircraft and engine types had to be checked over by the Aeronautics Branch of the Department of Commerce and certified safe according to stringent standards. All pilots and mechanics had to apply for a license. Pilots were subjected to a flying test and a physical examination; they also had to be attested as of

“good moral character.” Crucially, pilots could have their license revoked if they were considered to have flown dangerously – anything from flying while drunk to the frequent stunt of “buzzing” crowds at public events.

Concern for the safety of air passengers even led to the suggestion that they should all be issued with parachutes. This idea was hotly debated but never taken up, partly because it would have drawn attention to the dangers of flying, which was exactly the opposite of what the air industry and the federal aviation authorities wanted.

The Lindbergh factor

It was fortunate that the final handover of the airmail routes to private operators coincided with Lindbergh's solo flight across the Atlantic in 1927 (see page 118). Suddenly there was a surge of enthusiasm for aviation among the public and business investors alike. Flying schools flourished, money poured in for aircraft manufacturers, engine and propeller makers, and air-transportation companies, while city governments rushed to build new airports. But this wave of investment was based on optimism for the future, not current returns. Payment for airmail, calculated by weight carried, proved an unreliable source of income. Despite unscrupulous practices such as air companies flying stacks of mail addressed to their own offices or bumping up weight by slipping bricks into the mailbags, it was hard to turn a profit. Yet airmail carriers had little incentive to develop passenger transportation, because mail paid better.

The highest profile passenger service of the late 1920s was established by Transcontinental Air Transport (TAT), which took on Lindbergh as a consultant and marketed itself as the “Lindbergh Line.” As its name suggested, TAT was set up specifically to run a coast-to-coast service. Because of the dangers of night flying, this had to involve a mix of air and rail travel. Starting in July 1929, passengers could travel overnight by train from New York to Columbus, Ohio, board one of TAT's Ford Tri-Motors for a day's flight to Waynoka, Oklahoma, continue by overnight train to Clovis, New Mexico, and fly the last leg into Los Angeles. The two-day air-rail

FOKKER GROUNDED

IN MARCH 1931 A FOKKER F-10 Trimotor operated by TWA crashed in Kansas killing its crew and passengers. Among the eight victims was Notre Dame University football coach

Knute Rockne, one America's biggest sports personalities. Rockne's death filled the front pages and gave the US aviation industry a major

CELEBRITY VICTIM

Knute Rockne, an American sports hero, was one of the most famous people to have died in a plane crash.

crisis of confidence. The authorities had to identify the cause of the crash and remedy it. The finger of suspicion came to point at the F-10's wooden wing, the skin and spars of which were held together by glue. In an unprecedented step, the US aviation authorities banned all F-10s from passenger-carrying services. Anthony Fokker threatened legal action, but his airplane was doomed. Even when, under stringent conditions, the ban on Fokker Trimotors was later lifted, no one wanted to fly in them. Yet at the cost of a disaster for the Fokker Aircraft Corporation, public confidence in aviation safety standards was restored.

ACCIDENT SCENE

The wreckage of the TWA Fokker F-10 transport liner, in which Knute Rockne and seven others died, lies crumpled on a Kansas hillside. Witnesses to the crash were reported to have seen a wing tear off before it fell to the ground.



LOADING THE GOOSE

Cargo handlers load air-express packages onto a TWA Ford Tri-Motor in Kansas City in the 1930s. The “Tin Goose” is instantly recognizable from its thick corrugated metal wing and its underwing radial engine.

